



Claude Chabrol: Elements of Crime

Les Biches

Les Biches

Director: Claude Chabrol
Production Companies: Films La Boétie,
Alexandra Cinematografica
Producer: André Génovès
Production Manager: Georges Casati
Unit Production Manager: Patrick Delauneux
Administration: Henry Dutrannoy
Assistant Director: Claude Bakka
Script Supervisor: Aurore Paquiss
Screenplay: Paul Gégauff, Claude Gaillard
Director of Photography: Jean Rabier
Camera Operator: Claude Zidi
1st Assistant Camera: Paul Bonis
2nd Assistant Camera: Jeannine Rabier
Editor: Jacques Gaillard
Art Director: Marc Berthier
Costume Designer: Michel Albray
Music: Pierre Jansen
Sound: Guy Chichignoud
Sound Assistant: Gérard Dacquay
Cast:
Jean-Louis Trintignant (*Paul Thomas*)
Jacqueline Sassard (*Why*)
Stéphane Audran (*Frédérique*)
Nane Germon (*Violetta*)
Serge Bento (*Bookseller*)
Henri Attal (*Riais*)
Dominique Zardi (*Robègue*)
Claude Chabrol (*filmmaker*)*
France-Italy 1968
99 mins
Digital (restoration)

* Uncredited

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Even a film-crazy computer, fed with appropriate details of all 14 Chabrol features (and three sketches), from *Le Beau Serge* to *La Route de Corinth*, could hardly have come up with a more quintessentially Chabrolian film than *Les Biches*. Everything is here, from garrulous grotesques to idling rich, from atmosphere of sinister Hitchcockery to inversion in the roles of good and evil; yet there is one important difference, which makes this by far his most subtle and most controlled film to date.

Almost perversely, in telling a tale of perversion, Chabrol has given the film a deliberately muted air of tranquil elegance. Whether one chooses to explain this as a new maturity, or as the effect of an increasing transference of allegiance from Hitchcock to Fritz Lang (maybe this comes to the same thing?), the fact remains: somehow all the jagged nerves, jokery and crossed emotions are smoothed, toned down and neatly dovetailed into a texture of creamy gentleness, as doe-eyed as the murderous heroine herself. The result is a film which, in its exploration of the tortuous relationship between three people who can never be quite sure whether they are acting (in either sense) or being acted upon, maintains a constant tension between facts and appearances.

Right from the opening sequence, Chabrol plays cunningly on the disparity between the *seems* and the *is*. As the camera hovers hungrily, the hard-faced, elegantly predatory Frédérique (Stéphane Audran) circles around the poor, vulnerable young art student Why (Jacqueline Sassard), dropping a sensuous 500 franc note on the pavement beside her sketch before luring her inexorably up to her hotel room. Once there, however, Frédérique is placed in the position of humble suppliant, while Why, secure in the knowledge that she is needed more than she needs, becomes carelessly, cruelly exacting.

Already one can see, in silhouette as it were, the vulnerability behind Frédérique's hard shell (and vice versa with Why); and with wonderfully serpentine subtlety, Chabrol documents the process by which the two women literally change places. On the surface, as Why falls in love with a young architect (Jean-Louis Trintignant), and Frédérique, in seducing him to try to protect her property, herself falls madly in love with him, the film is a brilliant exercise in unconventional *marivaudage*; underneath, it is a strange labyrinth in which the characters are no longer able to distinguish between the *seems* and the *is* of their own emotions.

Does Why really love Paul, who regards her merely as a casual conquest, or is he simply an unattainable dream? Does Frédérique really love him, or is she simply making sure that Why remains attainable? And does Paul really love Frédérique, or simply cling to her as apparently less attainable than Why? While never answering in so many words, but proceeding by hints and suggestions, the film plots an unmistakably clear chart of their relationship. One notices, for instance, that Frédérique, for all her calculating exterior, is open-hearted and generous to her friends and the two parasitic gay men who have the freedom of her house; and that Why, on the contrary, barely talks to anyone if she can help it, and deliberately manoeuvres to get Frédérique's friends out of the house. One notices that Why, the virginal victim, has a white-walled bedroom, whereas those of the two seducers are blue (and blue is a softer, gentler colour than white). One notices a moment of cruelly ambiguous accuracy when Why

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Le Beau Serge

Thu 3 Sep 21:00; Sun 20 Sep 15:15 (+ intro by academic Catherine Dousteyssier-Khoze)

La Rupture

Fri 4 Sep 18:10; Sat 19 Sep 12:20; Sat 3 Oct 12:10
A double tour Web of Passion

Sat 5 Sep 14:30; Sat 19 Sep 14:50

The Third Lover

L'oeil du malin
Sat 5 Sep 18:20; Sat 19 Sep 20:45

The Beast Must Die

Que la bête meure
Sat 5 Sep 20:20; Thu 17 Sep 18:10 (+ intro by critic, lecturer and programmer Geoff Andrew);
Sun 4 Oct 18:10

Les Biches

Sun 6 Sep 18:30; Wed 23 Sep 20:40;
Sun 27 Sep 15:00; Mon 5 Oct 14:30

Juste avant la nuit

Just before Nightfall
Tue 8 Sep 20:45; Sun 27 Sep 12:10; Fri 2 Oct 14:30

Le Boucher

Wed 9 Sep 18:10 (+ intro by season curator Catherine Wheatley); Mon 21 Sep 20:50;
Fri 25 Sep 20:45; Sun 4 Oct 12:20; Tue 6 Oct 14:30

Philosophical Screens: Le Boucher

Wed 9 Sep 20:10 Blue Room

Wedding in Blood

Les noces rouges
Thu 10 Sep 18:10; Tue 15 Sep 21:00;
Tue 29 Sep 18:20

Ten Days' Wonder

La décade prodigieuse
Thu 10 Sep 20:30 (+ intro by season curator Catherine Wheatley); Sat 19 Sep 18:10

La Femme infidèle

The Unfaithful Wife
From Fri 11 Sep (Preview screening on Tue 1 Sep 20:30)

Violette Nozière

Sun 20 Sep 18:00 (+ intro by academic Catherine Dousteyssier-Khoze); Wed 30 Sep 20:30

The Hatter's Ghost

Les fantômes du chapelier
Tue 22 Sep 18:00; Mon 28 Sep 20:35

The Cry of the Owl

Le cri du hibou
Tue 22 Sep 20:55; Mon 28 Sep 18:00

Mean Girls: Claude Chabrol's Dangerous Women

Wed 23 Sep 18:15

The Swindle

Rien ne va plus
Fri 25 Sep 18:15; Sat 3 Oct 18:15 (+ intro by Claude Chabrol's daughter and collaborator Cécile Maistre-Chabrol)

The Colour of Lies

Au coeur du mensonge
Sat 26 Sep 15:00; Sun 4 Oct 15:10

Story of Women

Une affaire de femmes
Sat 26 Sep 17:50; Thu 1 Oct 20:30

La Cérémonie

Thu 1 Oct 18:00 (+ extended intro on queer Chabrol by academic Kit Francis Bradbury Rance);
Tue 6 Oct 20:45

The Bridesmaid

La demoiselle d'honneur
Sat 3 Oct 15:10; Mon 5 Oct 20:40 (+ intro by season curator Catherine Wheatley)

The Girl Cut in Two

La fille coupée en deux
Sat 3 Oct 20:40; Tue 6 Oct 18:00 (+ Q&A with Claude Chabrol's daughter and collaborator Cécile Maistre-Chabrol)

With thanks to

Tamasa Distribution

The BFI will be releasing a selection of Claude Chabrol's films on Blu-ray and DVD in 2027

bursts into tears after the departure of Paul and Frédérique to Paris, and the two gay men, annexing her despair to a game of 'What animal am I?' instantly recognise 'Crocodile tears!'

Much of the film is unequivocally funny, either in that characteristically ghoulish, pantomimic Chabrol manner, or in the cool insolence with which his camera circles the characters, picking out and displaying their foibles and manoeuvres like specimens on a drawing-board. The first encounter between Paul and Why at a party under Frédérique's baleful eye, for instance, is choreographed like a chess game, with sly glances making inroads into enemy territory and the camera triumphantly recording 'Mate!' by exactly reversing its viewpoint. There is, too, a deliciously funny sequence, central to the ambivalent relationships of the film and rhymed to Paul's attempts to tell a rambling story, which get more and more hesitant as both he and the two women get drunker and he gradually becomes aware of a curious triangular system of caresses.

Set pieces like this, or the wild eccentricities of the pair of grotesques, have been the staple of every Chabrol film since *Les Cousins*, but never before have they been so integrated into the texture of the film, or so subordinate to its theme. Stylistically, the tension between tormented content and tranquil form is so perfect that it is almost invisible. The battle royal for possession of each other between these three people takes place in a landscape of undisturbed beauty: pale pastels of St Tropez in the soft winter light echoing the delicately inexpressible emotions we witness; the soothingly elegant camera careful not to upset the delicate balance. *Les Biches*, appropriately titled in every way, is like some shy animal tiptoeing its way, surefooted and hesitating, through a treacherous bog.

Tom Milne, *Sight and Sound*, Winter 1968/9